

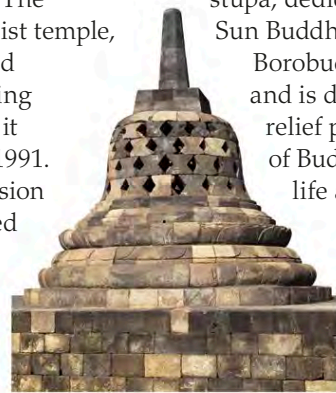


Borobudur

A massive temple in the form of a mandala, with exquisite carvings that narrate the Buddha's teachings and life story

Built high on a hill in central Java, Indonesia, during the Shailendra dynasty (750–850 CE), the temple at Borobudur is dedicated to the Buddha. The world's largest and most elaborate Buddhist temple, it was buried under volcanic ash in around 1000 CE and rediscovered in 1814. Following extensive restoration in the 20th century, it was designated a World Heritage Site in 1991. The monument is an architectural expression of a three-dimensional mandala—a sacred pattern, symbolic of the Universe, which is contemplated in meditation.

Built up from a square base (representing Earth), Borobudur consists of 10 mounting terraces



topped by a dome (representing Heaven). At the top of the structure is a large central stupa, dedicated to Vairochana, the Great Sun Buddha.

Borobudur has 504 statues of the Buddha and is decorated with 2,612 exquisitely carved relief panels, many of which narrate aspects of Buddhist scriptures and the Buddha's life and teachings.

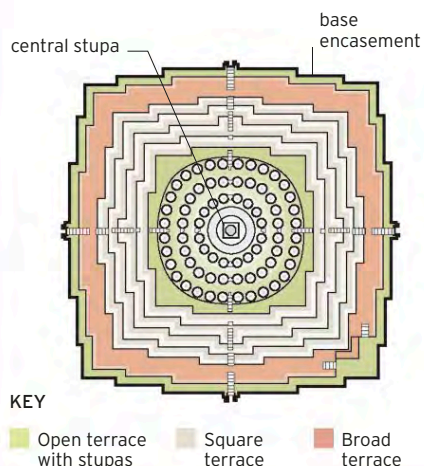
◁ PERFORATED STUPAS

The three circular layers of the temple feature 72 separate perforated, domed stupas, each containing a statue of the meditating Buddha.

Borobudur was built from **2,000,000 cubic ft (57,000 cubic m)** of volcanic stone blocks

THREE-DIMENSIONAL MANDALA

Borobudur was built to replicate a mandala, its sides facing the four cardinal directions of the compass. Its design guides devotees to walk clockwise, along walkways that encircle the central cosmic axis, to the summit. The ascent symbolizes a spiritual journey from the realm of earthly desires toward enlightenment.



△ RELIEF PANEL

Among Borobudur's most spectacular features are its decorative reliefs, which inspire pilgrims on their journey to the top of the temple. The main image in this carved panel is of the seated Buddha.

